

THE MURDER OF FIVE CHILDREN.

Mr. C. C. Lewis, the coroner for the southern division of Essex, held an inquest yesterday afternoon at the board room of the Walthamstow Cemetery, on the bodies of the five children—Charles, aged 3½ years; Herbert, aged 2½ years; and Frederick, aged 16 months, who were drowned; and two infant boys, aged seven days, unnamed, who were struck on the head with a hammer and killed by their father, William Gouldstone, on Wednesday night last. Inspector Craggs, of the N Division, watched the case on behalf of the Commissioners of Police. The first witness called was Ada Hamilton, the nurse to Mrs. Gouldstone, and she repeated the evidence she gave on the previous day before the magistrates. In addition she stated Gouldstone was sober at the time. She saw him the night previous at about 6 o'clock at tea time. He had had a holiday on Monday and Tuesday and at noon on the latter day he seemed as if he had been crying. He was very fond of his children, but when the twins were born he turned. He said that it was a very large family, and he wished they were dead. Gouldstone had never lost a day since he had been at work where he was. He was very steady, and his wife said she had never seen him but once the worse for liquor. Since the twins were born he had not looked at them, and he would not have gone to see his wife had she not persuaded him to do so. He earned 25s. a week.

The next witness called was Emma Clarke, wife of James Clarke, carpenter, of 8, Courtenay-place, St. James's-street, Walthamstow, who said:—My husband hired this house, in which William Gouldstone, his wife, and family had lodged eleven months. He was generally a steady man. I only saw him the worse for drink once; that was on Bank Holiday. He was a calm, placid man, and seemed to be very fond of his wife and kind to his three children. His wife was confined on August 1, at half-past 10 o'clock at night, her husband being at home. He was the worse for drink the next night, August 2. He seemed very strange when I told him of the birth of the twins, and he did not speak. The next night he was the worse for drink, but did not make any noise or any remark about the children. It was the first time I had seen him the worse for liquor. Last Wednesday night at about half-past 5 o'clock I was in the back garden hanging some clothes up, when the last witness, Mrs. Hamilton, called me. In consequence of this I ran upstairs as quickly as I could. I went to the bed room door, and found it fastened on the inside. I heard Mrs. Gouldstone say, "He's killed my babies." Mr. Gouldstone opened the door, and said, "You can come in; it's all done." I entered the room, and I stayed with Mrs. Gouldstone and the nurse. I saw the two babies lying on a pillow. They were breathing. Blood was flowing from their noses and mouths. Mrs. Hamilton covered them over with a sheet, and I went downstairs and called for the police, after which I returned to Mrs. Gouldstone's bed room. Presently I went into the kitchen with Mrs. Hamilton, and there saw the other children lying dead.

By the jury.—I have heard the mother say she wished the children dead. That was when she was worried, but I do not think she was in earnest. She never said it in conversation, but had remarked it to the children when they worried her.

William Cheeseman, police-constable, 26 N, stationed at Lea-bridge-road, who took the prisoner into custody, said.—On going to the house I saw William Gouldstone in the kitchen. He was in a stooping position over three children lying side by side on the floor. The three children appeared to be dead, and were thoroughly drenched with water. Gouldstone had his coat and hat off, and had his shirt-sleeves tucked up. As soon as he saw me he came towards the door and said, "Good evening, policeman; I have done it; now I am happy. I am ready for the rope." I cautioned him that whatever he said would be used in evidence against him. He then put on his coat and hat, and said, "Let me see my wife." I took him into the bed room, and his wife said, "Oh, you wicked man, what have you done?" He said, "I have killed all your children. Now you'll be single again, and I shall be killed." His wife said, "Have you any money?" He said, "Yes," and gave her all he had. He then kissed her and bade her "Good-bye." On the way to the police-station he said, "When I took my money last week I thought of buying a revolver to do it with, but I altered my mind, as I thought it would make too much noise. I had a hard job with the two eldest, but the other little one—I soon settled him. I thought it was getting too hot. I have had five children in about three years and a half, so I thought I would put a stop to it." At the police-station he said, "I've done it like a man," and when he was charged—the charge being read over to him by the inspector—with having murdered the three children, he said, "Quite right, Sir." The hammer produced I received from Mrs. Hamilton.

The inquiry was then adjourned.